



Ring the Liberty Bell

Declare your freedom from enslaved music.



services, and music publishers. Sadly, in India, most musicians and lyricists get almost nothing from this, as they often have to sign away their copyrights and ownership over their authored works to a film-producer or music company.

A call to freedom

Here's my rose-tinted vision of FOSS-based flower-power for such enslaved music. It's obvious the software to enable all this magic is locked away from the hands of end-users and geeks. So the four freedoms of GNU need to be applied to such software. Then, anyone, anywhere can set up their own CRBT servers and services, with any music they like – without being restricted by the limited offerings of existing providers. Anyone could then

share this music and service with their friends and communities. More obviously, software could be written to run directly off handsets, to set any existing music file on memory-cards as the CRBT for any caller, so anyone, anywhere could download any CRBT as a music file to their handsets.

Wring that tone

I am talking about the Caller Ring Back Tune (CRBT) that people have to endure, when they call you. Airtel for instance, markets this in India as 'Hello Tunes'. The irony of the situation is that on one hand, you haven't bought a single audio CD for years, in defiance against the music industry's anti-customer practices, and to rebel against the high price of Rs 100 to 400 per CD. You prefer instead to source music tracks accompanied by all the excitement and adventure of digital discovery. On the other hand, you're unwittingly playing right into the claws of the other powers-that-be when you activate CRBTs on your hand-phone.

As a typical example, you're paying Rs 15 to select a track, and then an additional Rs 30 per month to 'subscribe' to the service. That's Rs 375 per year. If you change the tune every month or week, or have different tunes set up for different users, add Rs 15 for each instance. So, whether it's Rs 375 or more than Rs 540 per annum, that is a lot of money to pay for a single track of music, which is not even physically in your possession or stored as a file on your handset. Heck! For all that money, you don't even get to listen to it yourself. Any caller to your number listens to only a few seconds of tinny-sounding music streaming into one ear.

Won and zero

Now zoom out to the bigger picture here. According to widely-published industry reports, India has nearly 500 million mobile phone users. So hypothetically, even if 10 per cent pay for some form of music subscriptions, that's about Rs 18 billion, or Rs 1,875 crore per annum. The actual user-base and revenue could be significantly higher. This services fee is distributed in three uneven chunks between mobile-service providers, outsourced companies providing such value-added-

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Free enterprise

Such freedom also entails the freedom to generate wealth out of *muft*-and-*mukt* software and services. Markets would be prised open from monopolies and cartels worldwide. The rules of free market enterprise would come into play. And this change can happen now. For instance, in a market crowded by mobile operators, sooner or later, a few will hit upon this idea to capture market share. Music services like Magnatune, and music published under Creative Commons licences could soon create their own buzzing communities that provide free music to mobile-users from Philadelphia to Phagwara and anywhere else in the world. These are interesting times, with the vision of Linux and FOSS extended to completely new paradigms of the new intangible economy of this century. Stay tuned for more bold ideas in the next column. 

About Niyam

Inspired by the vision of Osho. Copyright February 2010: Niyam Bhushan. [freedomyugs at gmail dot com](mailto:freedomyugs@gmail.com). First published in *LINUX For You* magazine. Verbatim copying, publishing and distribution of this article is encouraged in any language and medium, so long as this copyright notice is preserved. In Hindi, 'muft' means 'free-of-cost', and 'mukt' means 'with freedom'.